1) Title
Iran Clinical Trials Network

2) Author

Dr Sana Oladi, PhD (Health Science), with experience in clinical trials across both public cancer research in hospital settings and commercial studies across multiple therapeutic areas in private site networks. Currently working as a Feasibility Specialist at Momentum Clinical Trials, supporting a network of over 20 sites across Australia and New Zealand, based in Auckland.

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3) Abstract
Today, many people in Iran do not have access to the newest medicines and therapies that are available in other countries. This means fewer treatment options, slower improvements in care, and missed opportunities for patients who could benefit from innovative therapies earlier. At the same time, Iran has a strong base of doctors, scientists, and hospitals that could support high-quality clinical research. Clinical trials are how new medicines are tested and approved. They bring earlier access to treatments, improve healthcare systems, create skilled jobs, and attract global investment. Iran already has important foundations, including the Iranian Registry of Clinical Trials (IRCT), a World Health Organization-recognized registry, with over 35,000 trials registered as of April 2023. However, the current system is fragmented, slow in parts, and not yet fully aligned with international expectations. This proposal introduces a **Iran Clinical Trials Network**: a national, digital system that simplifies how trials are started, run, and monitored in Iran. It creates a single entry point for researchers and global partners, standardizes processes, supports ethical participant recruitment, builds workforce capability, and improves transparency. The goal is to make Iran a trusted, efficient, and attractive location for clinical research.

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4) Why It's Interesting
Iran is not starting from zero. The **Iranian Registry of Clinical Trials (IRCT)** is a World Health Organization-recognized registry, with over 35,000 trials registered as of April 2023. This shows strong research activity and engagement.
However, volume alone does not create a competitive system. Analyses of Iran's regulatory framework, established in 2003, highlight the need for clearer processes, stronger oversight, and better alignment with international expectations. IRCT does not currently provide public posting of trial results, which can limit transparency and global confidence.
This creates a clear gap:
Iran has the talent and infrastructure, but lacks a **coordinated, predictable, and trusted system** for delivering clinical trials.

At the same time, Iran has a unique opportunity:

- Many patients have not yet received newer treatments
- There is a large pool of skilled clinicians
- A young workforce can be trained quickly

Countries that attract clinical trials have solved this through system design:

- Australia reduces duplication through simplified approval pathways
- New Zealand provides clear national ethics and regulatory processes
- The United Kingdom coordinates trials across sites nationally

Iran can adopt these principles in a way that fits its own system.
The opportunity is to move from fragmented activity to a connected national capability.

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5) Approach
The platform will act as a **national operating system for clinical trials**, combining digital tools, standard processes, and workforce development.

User	What They Can Do on the Platform	Value Delivered
Sponsors & Feasibility Specialists	Register new trials, assess feasibility using real data, compare with historical performance, select sites, track progress	Faster, data-driven decisions and reduced uncertainty
Investigators (Doctors)	View relevant trials, submit site interest, access standard templates, manage study activities	Easier trial participation and reduced admin burden
Site Staff (Coordinators, Nurses)	Follow guided workflows, complete training, manage visits and data, track patient recruitment	Consistent quality and simplified day-to-day operations
Hospitals, Private Research Sites, GP & Specialist Clinics	Register as trial sites, showcase capabilities, receive matched studies, participate in trials	Broader participation and increased trial opportunities

Patients & Public	Search trials in plain language, filter by condition/location, register interest safely, access clear information	Improved access, understanding, and trust
Regulators & Ethics Committees	Receive structured submissions, review within standard workflows, track approvals, maintain audit trails	Faster, more consistent and transparent approvals
Ministry of Health & Policymakers	Access national dashboards, monitor trial activity, identify gaps, guide funding decisions	Better policy and strategic planning
Research Institutions & Universities	Identify collaborations, join multi-site studies, access national data, support training	Stronger research collaboration and capability building

A. One Entry Point
A single online portal for sponsors, researchers, hospitals, private research units, and clinics.

- Step-by-step guidance from submission to trial launch
- Information entered once and reused
- Automatic routing to ethics and regulatory bodies

Outcome: simpler, faster, and clearer trial initiation

B. Standardized Trial Start-Up
A national workflow used across all sites:

- Site selection based on expertise and patient access
- Structured ethics and regulatory submission pathways
- Standard contract and budget templates

Outcome: reduced delays and predictable timelines

C. A National Network of Trial Sites
Include:

- Hospitals and academic centers
- Purpose-built private research units
- GP and specialist clinics with research capability

All sites operate under **consistent standards and systems**.

Outcome: faster participant recruitment and broader patient access

D. Workforce Training and Certification

- Role-based training for doctors, coordinators, and nurses
- Practical, task-focused modules
- Certification linked to platform use

Outcome: consistent quality across all sites

E. Ethical Participant Recruitment

- Public, plain-language trial listings
- Search by condition and location
- Secure “register interest” system
- Culturally appropriate communication

Outcome: improved access, faster participant recruitment, and public trust

F. Transparency and Trust

- Plain-language summaries of trials
- Clear tracking of trial status
- Pathway for responsible results sharing
- Integration with IRCT

Outcome: increased national and international confidence

G. National Insights

Real-time data on:

- Diseases being studied
- Gaps in research
- Site performance and capacity

Outcome: better policy, funding, and planning decisions

Implementation Approach

- Start with **pilot sites** (hospitals + private clinics)
- Test full workflows end-to-end
- Refine and scale nationally

Principle: start small, prove value, then expand

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6) Help Needed
Leadership

- National body to own and coordinate the platform
- Agreement on standard processes

Sites

- Hospitals, private research units, GP and specialist clinics
- Participation in pilots and adoption of standard workflows

People

- Investigators, coordinators, and research nurses
- Trainers to scale workforce capability

Technology

- Platform development and data security
- Simple, user-focused design

Funding

- Government seed funding
- Private and international co-investment

Partnerships

- Pharmaceutical and biotech companies
- Contract research organisations
- Academic collaborators

IRCT Alignment

- Integration with existing registry
- Improved visibility and structured results sharing over time

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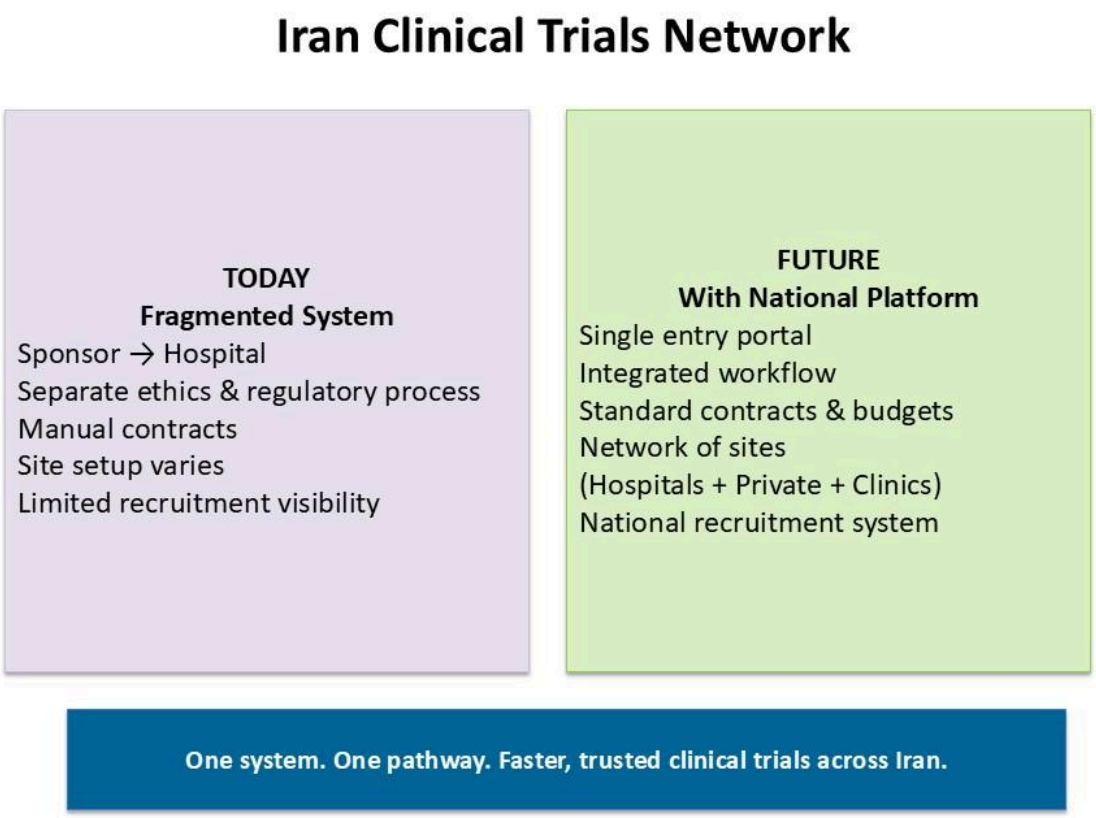
7) Supporting Material

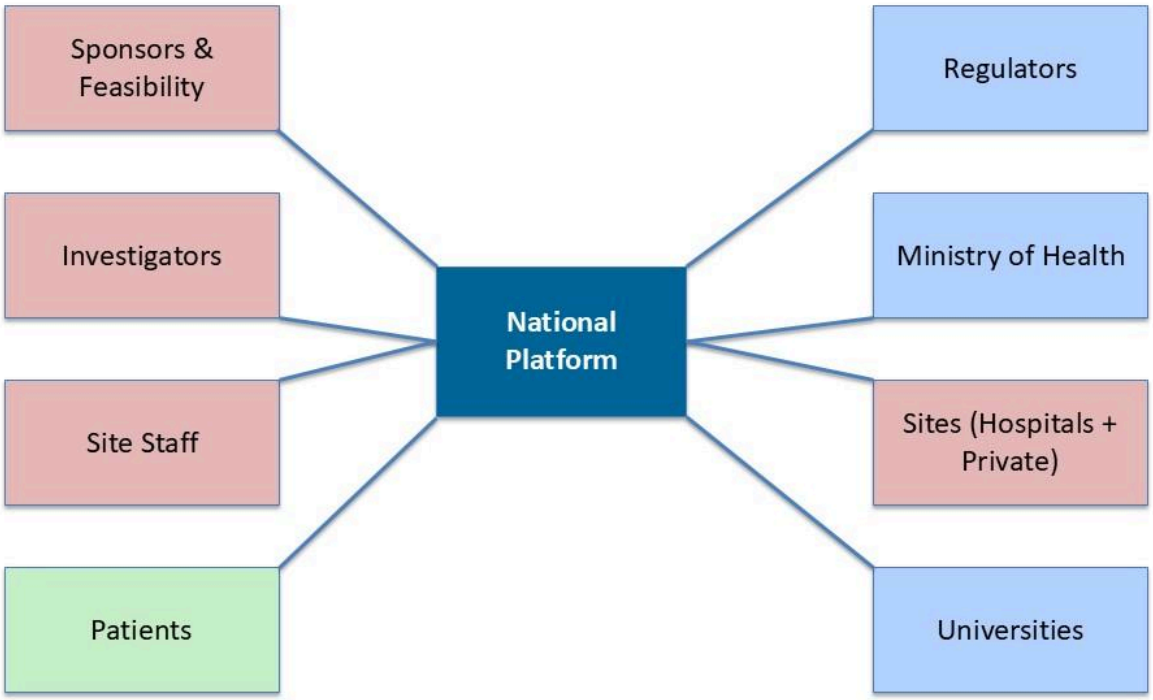


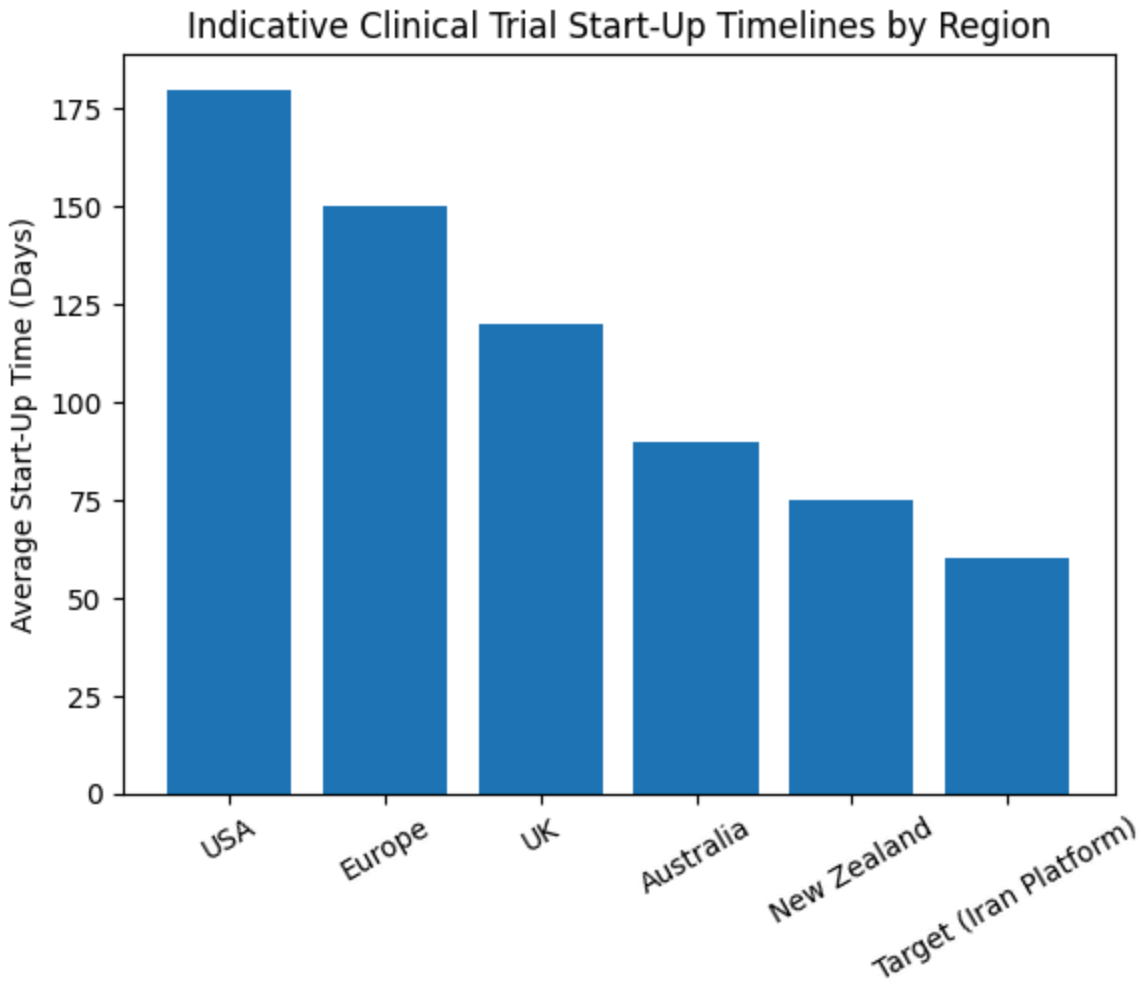
What Success Looks Like

1. Time to start a trial significantly reduced
2. Number of active trial sites (including private clinics) increased
3. Number of trained and certified staff
4. Number of international partnerships
5. Number of trials launched annually
6. Participant satisfaction and engagement

This platform will position Iran as one of the strongest emerging players in the global clinical trials industry,a rapidly growing, multi-billion dollar market — unlocking earlier access to treatments, high-value jobs, and international investment.

Iran Clinical Trials Network Ecosystem




Indicative Clinical Trial Start-Up Timelines by Region
Average Start-Up Time (Days)
0
25
50
75
100
125
150
175
USA
Europe
UK
Australia
New Zealand
Target (Iran Platform)